

CILLIERS · 2011 · ORIGINAL RESEARCH

Positive psychology leadership coaching

Experiences in a financial organisation

Presentation time: 15-16 minutes · approximately 2.5 minutes per speaker

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Who will present each section

Group presentation structure

01

Mehr-un-Nisa Shafiq

Introduction, Author, History and Research Problem

02

Saira Abbasi

Theory and Conceptual Framework

03

Usman Zameer

Research Philosophy and Methodology

04

Zeeshan Sikander

Findings Part One

05

Tahmina Ghaffar

Findings Part Two and Discussion

06

Mahjabeen

Critical Evaluation and Conclusion

Six speakers · one connected argument



FC

INDUSTRIAL AND
ORGANISATIONAL
PSYCHOLOGY

A psychologist studying leadership from inside the coaching relationship

- 01 Industrial and organisational psychology academic at the University of South Africa
- 02 Registered psychologist with practical experience in positive psychology and leadership coaching
- 03 Trained in person-centred, Rogerian facilitation
- 04 Served as the external consultant, coach and researcher in this study

How the study emerged

Introduction, Author, History and Research Problem



The article sits where growing coaching practice met a shortage of qualitative evidence.

Why Cilliers published the study

Introduction, Author, History and Research Problem

A real organisational need exposed a gap in the research

- Leaders relied heavily on targets, rules and positional authority
- Colleagues experienced weak listening, care and understanding
- Earlier studies examined isolated coaching outcomes
- No qualitative study combined all five constructs used in this programme

Research question: How can weak people-leadership awareness in a financial organisation be addressed successfully?

Positive psychology in leadership

Theory and Conceptual Framework

The programme treated leadership development as growth in self-awareness, internal motivation and interpersonal connection

- Strengths and psychological resources
- Meaning, engagement and responsibility
- Emotional awareness
- Relationships that support growth

The field already contained a warning

Theory and Conceptual Framework

Promise

- 01 Stronger engagement
- 02 Greater self-efficacy
- 03 Improved management effectiveness
- 04 More positive affect

Risk

- 01 Practice could outpace evidence
- 02 Positive language could hide difficult emotions
- 03 Some clients may resist relationships and growth
- 04 Task results could overshadow people leadership

Five constructs shaped the coaching

Theory and Conceptual Framework

01

Work engagement

Energy and involvement

02

Learned resourcefulness

Regulating thoughts and emotions

03

Sense of coherence

Making demands understandable and manageable

04

Self-actualisation values

Growing towards one's potential

05

Internal locus of control

Believing one's actions influence outcomes

The conceptual leadership profile

Theory and Conceptual Framework

1

**Engage with
the role of
leader**

2

**Understand
the move from
management
to leadership**

3

**Recognise
emotional
demands**

4

**Authorise
oneself to act**

5

**Create growth
opportunities
for others**

Research philosophy

Research Philosophy and Methodology

1

Ontology

Leadership reality
appears through lived
and contextual
experience

2

Epistemology

Knowledge develops
through reflection and
interaction

3

Paradigm

Interpretive and
constructivist reading with
participatory action

4

Methodology

Qualitative descriptive
case study

The article does not explicitly name its ontology or epistemology; this reading follows its design and assumptions.

Research design

Research Philosophy and Methodology

One bounded coaching programme became the case

- Qualitative and descriptive approach
- Participatory action research
- Intrinsic case: understand this programme deeply
- Instrumental case: inform leadership development in the organisation

Participants and coaching process

Research Philosophy and Methodology

26

leaders invited

11

accepted

10

one-hour sessions

10

weeks

- Seven men and four women, aged 24 to 41
- Five Black and six White participants
- Convenience sample of advancement-potential leaders
- Coach observed one meeting chaired by each participant

From experience to findings

Research Philosophy and Methodology

1

Field notes

Recorded during and
after coaching

2

Reflective essays

About five pages from
each participant

3

Discourse analysis

Familiarisation,
categorising and
interpretation

4

Six themes

Working hypotheses
linked experience to
theory

Quality: peer review by two psychologists, prolonged engagement, consent, confidentiality and organisational permission.

Six themes emerged

Findings Part One

01

Coaching context

02

Engagement in role

03

**Understanding role
complexity**

04

Emotional self-awareness

05

Self-authorisation

06

**Inability to facilitate
others' growth**

The coaching context

Findings Part One

Early sessions

- 01 Strange and uncomfortable
- 02 Unclear purpose
- 03 Resistance to feelings
- 04 Talking around the real issue

Later sessions

- 01 Self-discovery
- 02 Connections between behaviour and relationships
- 03 Greater curiosity
- 04 A sense of relief and learning

Engagement in the leadership role

Findings Part One

Initial pattern

- 01 People treated like numbers
- 02 Technical work felt safer
- 03 Difficult meetings were avoided

Emerging change

- 01 More energy for people issues
- 02 Greater involvement
- 03 Problems reframed as possibilities

Participants preferred financial tasks because people problems made them feel tired and incompetent

Understanding role complexity

Findings Part One

Technical success did not automatically produce effective leadership

- Management focused on measurable personal performance
- Leadership required outcomes through other people
- Interpersonal situations felt less predictable
- Leaders needed experience followed by further coaching

Emotional self-awareness

Findings Part Two and Discussion

The leaders moved from intellectualising feelings towards recognising and expressing them

- Feelings initially seemed irrelevant or unsafe
- Several participants suppressed difficult emotions
- Coaching increased self-acceptance and emotional vocabulary
- Awareness remained stronger inside the self than inside relationships

Self-authorisation

Findings Part Two and Discussion

External orientation

- 01 Blaming the organisation
- 02 Depending on formal authority
- 03 Looking outward for permission
- 04 Task-based identity

Internal orientation

- 01 Taking responsibility
- 02 Using personal principles
- 03 Making conscious choices
- 04 Drawing on inner resources

The interpersonal gap remained

Findings Part Two and Discussion

The programme improved self-awareness more than the ability to develop other people

- Meetings remained content-driven and instructional
- Autocratic and telling styles limited connection
- Leaders missed emotional cues
- Listening, empathy and developmental conversation remained weak

How the findings connect with theory

Findings Part Two and Discussion

- 01 **Work engagement increased as leaders invested energy in people issues**
- 02 **Sense of coherence improved as leadership became more understandable and meaningful**
- 03 **Internal locus of control supported self-authorisation**
- 04 **Emotional intelligence developed mainly within the self**
- 05 **Leadership style moved away from command, but active listening remained limited**

What the study actually concludes

Critical Evaluation and Conclusion

- 01 Intrapersonal awareness improved
- 02 Leaders identified and expressed needs and feelings more openly
- 03 They understood the cognitive and emotional complexity of leadership
- 04 The programme did not sufficiently develop interpersonal effectiveness

Critical evaluation

Critical Evaluation and Conclusion

Strengths

- 01 Rich field notes and participant essays**
- 02 Clear connection between theory and observed behaviour**
- 03 Prolonged engagement and independent peer review**
- 04 Honest reporting of the programme's limitation**

Limitations

- 01 Small convenience sample from one organisation**
- 02 Coach and researcher were the same person**
- 03 Ten weeks may have been too short**
- 04 Discourse analysis depended heavily on subjective interpretation**

What we would do differently

Critical Evaluation and Conclusion

01

Separate the coaching and research roles

02

Include interviews or observations by an independent researcher

03

Observe behaviour over a longer period

04

Add feedback from direct reports and colleagues

05

Practise listening and responding through role-play

06

Follow participants after the programme

Leadership implication

Positive inner change matters only when other people can experience it

Integrate coaching with leadership-development programmes

Develop interpersonal skills as deliberately as self-awareness

Use observation, feedback and practice in real work settings

Treat difficult emotions as part of leadership rather than a failure of positivity

Final takeaway: self-awareness opens the door; relational behaviour determines whether leadership walks through it.